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Appeasing Populist Leaders

DONALD TRUMP took a particularly hostile stance toward the WTO during his first term. Throughout, he openly criticized the organization, threatened to withdraw the United States from it entirely, and disregarded its rules and norms. This hostility was not simply rhetorical: Trump blocked the appointment of judges to the WTO's dispute-settlement body and imposed tariffs on trading partners that directly violated WTO rules.[1] These actions sparked concerns about cascading noncompliance, with fears that other states might follow suit, potentially destabilizing the global trade regime and jeopardizing the WTO's very survival.

In response, the WTO made several attempts to appease the United States, focusing on reforms to its Appellate Body—the primary target of Trump's criticism. Proposed changes included limiting the length of appeals, introducing term limits for Secretariat staff, establishing an audit committee, removing advisory opinions, and ensuring that precedents would not bind future cases. While these concessions failed to satisfy Trump, they demonstrate the lengths to which the WTO was willing to go to mollify his administration.[2]

This pattern of IOs making concessions to defuse populist pressure is not unique to the WTO. The European Union faced similar challenges when Hungary, under populist leader Viktor Orbán, blocked the ratification of the post-Cotonou Agreement with seventy-nine African, Caribbean, and Pacific states in 2021. Orbán objected to the agreement's migration policies and its